

Orthability, Divine Attributes, and Speech - Athari (companion draft)

DRAFT - not peer reviewed.

Empirical validation not completed: no designed study has been run.

Terminology benchmark not run: every coined term is a candidate; none adopted.

Companion claim status: philosophical conclusions are conditional on stated premises;

creed-internal material is explicitly school-labeled (Athari) and revelational where stated.

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Orthability, the Divine Attributes, and the Uncreated Speech of Allah: An Atharī Creed-Internal Development

Status: complete creed-internal DRAFT (R2, 2026-07-20). EXPLICITLY ATHARĪ / school-internal — this paper develops one route within Sunni theology (the Atharī/Ḥanbalī, and specifically Taymiyyan, articulation) and is NOT presented as a neutral conclusion of philosophy, nor as the position of every Islamic school. Not peer reviewed. Claim types labeled analytic, transcendental, explanatory, metaphysical, revelational, or school-internal. Philosophical prerequisites are imported from the school-neutral companion (orthability-and-the-ground-of-intelligibility.md), whose §8 boundary — reason reaches at most a capacity for disclosure — governs everything here: every claim beyond it rests on revelation and transmitted creed, and is labeled so. Sourcing: Qurʾānic āyāt are cited by sūrah:āyah ("interpretation of the meaning" for renderings); classical loci marked [via compilation] are taken from an attributed tradition-internal compilation naming its primary sources with volume/page; the printed editions were not independently opened, and this flag is a real limitation recorded in sourcing/COMPANION-SOURCING-LEDGER.md. The operational manuscript proves nothing here (absolute firewall), and nothing here is evidence for the operational framework.

1. Eight things that must not be collapsed

The whole discipline of this paper is to keep distinct, and correctly relate, eight items:

1. Allah's eternal Knowledge of all possibilities — including every determinate linguistic possibility (§4);
2. Allah's perfection and attribute of Speech — He has always been One who speaks, never acquiring the capacity (§3);
3. Particular acts of divine Speech occurring when He wills — His speaking to Mūsā, to Ādam, the sending down of the Qurʾān (§3);
4. Allah's uncreated Speech — His Speech is His attribute, and His attributes are not created (§3);
5. The Qurʾān as Allah's uncreated Arabic Speech — a particular Speech He spoke, in Arabic, uncreated (§3, §5);
6. Created human recitation acts — voices, bodily movements, breath, memorization, and the media: ink, pages, screens (§5);
7. Created historical human Arabic — speakers, conventions, dialects, scripts, grammarians' descriptions (§4);
8. The eternally known possibility of those created linguistic instantiations — item 7 as encompassed, before its existence, by item 1 (§4).

Most classical errors on this topic, and most modern restatements of them, are collapses of two or more of these — the Jahmī/Muʿtazilī collapse of 4–5 into 6–7 ("the Qurʾān is created"), the collapse of 3 into 1 (speech reduced to knowledge), or the reification of 8 into a second eternal entity beside Allah (§4). (School-internal taxonomy.)

2. From the philosophical companion to the creed: what carries over and what does not

The school-neutral companion argued, transcendently and conditionally, to an underived ground of intelligibility — knowing, willing, powerful, wise, and not intrinsically incapable of disclosure. Within the Atharī creed, that ground is identified as Allah, and the identification itself is revelational, not philosophical: reason's role was preparatory (removing the alleged impossibility of an uncreated ground of meaning and disclosure), and revelation's role is constitutive (telling us who has spoken and what He said). The creed-internal summary

of the philosophical residue, in the owner-approved anti-Platonist form:

> Every created act of orthing presupposes an uncreated orthability of being: for any created agent, process, system, or language to resolve, distinguish, signify, classify, or correctly handle anything at all, reality must already be antecedently determinable, differentiable, modally ordered, and fit for lawful resolution. This orthability cannot itself be wholly created, because the intelligible coming-to-be of orthability would already presuppose orthability. In the Atharī framing, that ground is not an autonomous Platonic order but is grounded in Allah's uncreated Knowledge and Speech; created languages and practices instantiate, within creation, possibilities eternally known by Allah. (Transcendental core + school-internal identification, labeled as such.)

3. The attribute of Speech: the Atharī articulation

3.1 That Allah truly speaks, with speech that is heard

The creed's basis is textual. "And who is truer in statement than Allah?" (4:87); "and whose words can be truer than those of Allah?" (4:122) — He speaks, and His words are true. "And [remember] when Allah will say: O 'Īsā son of Maryam..." (5:116) — His speech is heard. "O Mūsā, verily I am your Lord" (20:11) — words composed of letters. "And We called him from the right side of the Mount, and made him draw near for a talk" (19:52) — calling and conversing occur with sound. And the rule governing all of it: "There is nothing like Him, and He is the All-Hearer, the All-Seer" (42:11) — His speech, letters, and sound do not resemble creatures'. This is the articulation found in Ibn 'Uthaymīn's commentary on Lum'at al-l'tiqād (p. 73) [via compilation]: Allah speaks in a real sense, when and as and with whatever He wills, with letters and sound befitting Him. (Revelational + school-internal.)

3.2 Perfection, genus, and particulars: the precise Taymiyyan distinctions

Four distinctions, each doing real work:

- The perfection is eternal. Allah has always been capable of speech and has never lacked the perfection of speaking; being capable of speech means He speaks at will. (School-internal; the denial would attribute a deficiency later remedied — excluded.)
- The genus is eternal; the particulars occur when He wills. In the Taymiyyan formulation, the kind — that He speaks — is eternal, while particular speeches occur successively by His Will: His speaking to Ādam is a different instance from His speaking to Mūsā; the Qur'ān is a particular Speech He spoke to Jibrīl, spoken at a point after not having been spoken. This is Ibn Taymiyyah's known position on divine speech (developed across Majmū' al-Fatāwā vol. 12 and elsewhere; academic treatment in Hoover 2004), and it is what the owner-adopted formulation states: genus eternal → particulars occur → particulars are not beginningless → there is order in the letters and sounds, and internal order excludes a beginningless single utterance. (School-internal; Taymiyyan/Ḥanbalī articulation specifically — see §7 for the contrasting Sunni account.)
- "Not beginningless" does not mean "created." A particular occurrence is not thereby a creature: the Qur'ān is a particular Speech, spoken when He willed, and it is uncreated, because speech is an attribute subsisting in the Speaker, and Allah's attributes are not created. The pair (particular occurrence, created thing) must never be identified. (School-internal; the load-bearing anti-collapse of items 3 and 4 against 6–7.)
- "Eternal" requires disambiguation before use. The formulae "the Qur'ān is eternal" and "the Qur'ān is not eternal" are both forbidden unqualified. Qualified: the perfection and genus of Speech are eternal; the Qur'ān as a particular Speech was spoken when Allah willed (in that sense not a beginningless individual utterance); and it is uncreated. Imām Aḥmad's reported courtroom formula "the word of Allah, ancient and uncreated" (in the later Ḥanbalī report of Ṭabaqāt al-Ḥanābilah 219 [via compilation]; the narrative has hagiographic features and is cited as tradition-internal report, not verified history) uses "ancient" (qadīm) in the sense the school reads as: His Speech as attribute, not a claim that the recited sequence is beginningless. (School-internal, with

the source-critical caution stated.)

3.3 The classical proofs that the Qur'ān is not created

The tradition's argument set, as compiled from the primary loci [via compilation], includes: the creation/command distinction — "Surely His is the creation and the command" (7:54), with creation occurring through the command "Be!" (36:82), so that if the command were created it would require a prior command, ad infinitum (argued by Sufyān ibn 'Uyaynah and Imām Aḥmad; al-Ājurri, ash-Sharī'ah p. 80; Ḥanbal, al-Miḥnah 53–54); the knowledge argument — "The Most Merciful taught the Qur'ān; He created man" (55:1–3), the Qur'ān being from His knowledge (2:120; 3:61), and His knowledge is not created (Aḥmad against al-Qazzāz, al-Miḥnah 45); the inexhaustibility argument (18:109; 31:27); the names argument — His names occur in the Qur'ān and are glorified, invoked, and sworn by (87:1; 7:180; 76:25), which would be shirk if created (ath-Thawrī; ash-Shāfi'ī on expiation, Ādāb ash-Shāfi'ī 193); the attribution argument — He attributes the revealed Book to Himself as His word (32:2; 6:114; 16:102; 9:6, the last by scholarly consensus about the Qur'ān); the seeking-refuge ḥadīth — "I seek refuge in the perfect words of Allah..." (Muslim 2708), refuge being sought only in Allah and His attributes (Nu'aym ibn Ḥammād; al-Bukhārī, Khalq Af'āl al-'Ibād p. 143); the superiority ḥadīth (ad-Dārimī, ar-Radd 'alā al-Jahmiyyah 287, 340); and the two rational proofs — an attribute does not subsist by itself but in the one it describes, so speech attributed to Allah is His attribute and uncreated, whereas the same attribute-kind attributed to a creature is created like the creature (the ninth proof), and the dilemma against created-speech-in-Him or created-speech-outside-Him, the latter yielding the bush absurdity: if the words heard by Mūsā were the bush's created words, "Verily I am Allah, Lord of the worlds" (28:30) would stand to Pharaoh's "I am your lord most high" (79:24) with no principled difference — a consequence the tradition treats as self-refuting for the created-speech thesis (the eighth proof; Aḥmad in al-Miḥnah 52). (Revelational + school-internal argumentation, reported with its own loci; this paper adds no claim that these arguments compel the philosophical reader — they are the creed's internal case.)

4. Arabic and the "uncreated grammar" metaphor

4.1 The three-level account (with the fourth level made explicit)

Before there were Arabic-speaking humans, scripts, grammarians, mouths pronouncing phonemes, or manuscripts in the dunyā, Allah already knew: every possible Arabic sound and form; every root, pattern, inflection, syntactic relation, and semantic distinction; every possible correct and incorrect construction; every context in which an expression would bear one meaning rather than another; and the exact ordered words of the Qur'ān He would speak. Hence the levels:

1. Uncreated divine Knowledge. Allah's knowledge of Arabic's complete possibility-space is not acquired from created Arabic and does not wait for Arabic to emerge historically: Arabic's complete orthability is encompassed by what Allah eternally knows. (School-internal, resting on the doctrine of His eternal, uncreated Knowledge.)
2. The eternal attribute and perfection of Speech (§3.2's first distinction) — inserted explicitly so that Knowledge and Speech are not collapsed (§6).
3. Allah's particular uncreated acts of speaking — including the Arabic Qur'ān, spoken when He willed, in real ordered words and letters, with a sound befitting Him (§3.2).
4. Created Arabic instantiation. Arabic as historically instantiated among creatures — vocal organs, conventional usages, dialect development, writing systems, grammatical descriptions — is created. Creatures do not create the underlying possibility of intelligible linguistic order out of absolute unintelligibility; they instantiate, discover, conventionalize, and modify particular created forms within a possibility-space already known to Allah.

Two forbidden sentences, and their corrections. It is wrong to say categorically "Arabic speech is created": creaturely Arabic utterances, voices, and media are created; Allah's Arabic Speech — the Qur'ān — is uncreated. The category "Arabic speech" straddles items 5 and 7 of §1 and must be divided before predication. And it is wrong to say "letters and sounds existed as created objects before letters and sounds were created": nothing of the sort is claimed at level 1 — what "precedes" created Arabic is not a shadow-Arabic of created letters but Allah's Knowledge and His Speech; He never lacked the perfection of Speech, He speaks when He wills, particular speeches occur in an ordered manner, His Speech including the Qur'ān is uncreated, and creaturely phonation and inscription are created. (School-internal precision rules.)

4.2 "Uncreated grammar," defined and defused

The phrase "uncreated grammar" may be used only as a defined philosophical metaphor: shorthand for the divine-side ground of expressibility, determinacy, lawful relation, and fitting signification — that is, for levels 1–2 as they bear on language. It must not be reified as: a second eternal entity; a Platonic Arabic subsisting alongside Allah; or a created human grammar book existing before creation. The possibility-space of language is not a thing beside Allah; talk of it is talk of what Allah eternally knows and of what His Speech is adequate to. Anywhere the metaphor cannot be paraphrased away in that manner, it is being misused. (School-internal anti-reification rule, matching the anti-Platonism of the philosophical companion.)

4.3 The Qur'ān within the three levels

The Qur'ān is not a human Arabic construction that Allah selected after Arabic independently arose. Its exact wording is Allah's Speech. The created historical existence of Arabic speakers is the condition for their reception and recitation of the Arabic Qur'ān — not the ontological source of Allah's ability to speak it: Allah's Speech and Knowledge (uncreated) → the Arabic Qur'ān revealed to creation (heard and read through created media). (School-internal.)

5. The reciter's act and the carried Word

When a human recites: the human is created; tongue, mouth, movement, and breath are created; the reciter's voice is created; the act of reciting is created. But what is recited — the words — are the words of the Creator. "The words are the words of the Creator, and the voice is the voice of the reciter" (Ibn Taymiyyah, *Majmū' al-Fatāwā* 12/98; similarly 12/53; the Permanent Committee, *Fatāwā al-Lajnah ad-Dā'imah* 3/21) [via compilation]. Al-Bukhārī devoted *Khalq Af'āl al-'Ibād* to exactly this division: the servants' movements, voices, acquisitions, and writing are created; the Qur'ān that is recited, written in the *muṣḥaf*, and preserved in breasts (29:49; 80:13–14; 98:2–3) is the Word of Allah, uncreated (2/70 and passim; Ishāq ibn Ibrāhīm: "As for the vessels, who would doubt that they are created?") [via compilation]. Hence it is misleading to say simply "the written Qur'ān is created" or "the heard Qur'ān is created": the ink, page, and voice are created vessels; what they carry is the uncreated Word — and the historical Ḥanbalī caution about *lafẓ* formulations (refusing both "my utterance of the Qur'ān is created" and its denial, as ambiguous between act and content) is precisely a refusal to let a vessel-sentence blur the carried-Word distinction. (School-internal.)

6. Theological precision: the attributes and their distinctions

- Knowledge encompasses all possibilities and actualities eternally; it does not come to be. — Will selects among possibilities for creation and for His acts. — Power actualizes what He wills. — Wisdom is the fitting ordering of what He decrees and commands. — Speech is His attribute of address and disclosure: informative and imperative, spoken when He wills.
- Why Speech must not collapse into Knowledge: the Mu'tazilī reduction ("the Qur'ān expresses His knowledge,

and calling it His speech is metaphor") erases item 3 of §1 — the Qur'ānic texts describe address, calling, and audible speaking (5:116; 19:52; 4:164), not mere content-possession. The knowledge argument of §3.3 relates the Qur'ān to His knowledge evidentially (it is from His knowledge); it does not identify the attributes. Symmetrically, Speech must not collapse into Will-plus-created-sound (the Karrāmī/Jahmī picture of created speech in a substrate — refuted by the bush absurdity, §3.3).

- Why possibility-space must not become an entity: §4.2's rule, restated at attribute level — the ground of intelligibility is Allah with His attributes, not an abstract order beside Him and not a fifth thing between Creator and creation. (School-internal.)

- The paper's route-specificity, stated once more: everything in §§3-6 is the Atharī (and specifically Taymiyyan-inflected) articulation. (Label.)

7. The contrasting Sunni account, described neutrally

The Ash'arī and Māturīdī schools affirm — against the Mu'tazilah, and together with the Atharīs — that Allah speaks and that His speech is uncreated. Their articulation differs: Allah's Speech is an eternal attribute subsisting in His essence as kalām nafsī (internal speech/meaning), without letters, sounds, or succession; the recited Arabic Qur'ān is, on the Ash'arī account, a created expression ('ibārah) of that eternal Speech — so that "the Qur'ān is the uncreated Speech of Allah" is affirmed of the kalām nafsī while the articulated wording's status is analyzed differently than in §3. On this account the Atharī "letters and sound, when He wills" articulation is rejected as attributing succession (ḥulūl al-ḥawādith) to the divine essence; conversely, Atharī authors object that kalām nafsī makes the revealed Arabic not literally His Speech. **This paper does not adjudicate that intra-Sunni dispute and does not represent either side as the uncontested meaning of Ahl as-Sunnah wa-l-Jamā'ah; it develops the Atharī route, and this paragraph exists so the reader cannot mistake the route for the whole map.** The description above is the standard textbook contrast; a genuinely Ash'arī/Māturīdī tradition-internal source was not independently verified in this pass, and the comparative route remains blocked on that verification (recorded limitation). (Neutral description; verification residual flagged.)

8. Reason and revelation: the final accounting

Claim Basis
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An underived ground of intelligibility, not intrinsically incapable of disclosure Philosophical (transcendental + conditional; school-neutral companion, with its stated exits)
That the ground is Allah, who has truly spoken Revelational
That His Speech is uncreated; letters and sound befitting Him; heard by whom He wills Revelational + school-internal (Atharī articulation, §3)
Genus eternal; particular speeches when He wills; particular ≠ created School-internal (Taymiyyan precision, §3.2)
The Qur'ān is His uncreated Arabic Speech; the reciter's voice and the media are created Revelational + school-internal (§5)
Arabic's possibility-space eternally known; created Arabic instantiated within it; no reified "uncreated grammar" School-internal synthesis (§4), consistent with — not proven by — the philosophical companion
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Reason, at its strongest here, removes alleged impossibilities and exhibits presuppositions. It does not recite. What the Qur'ān is — Allah's Word, uncreated, "and if anyone of the polytheists seeks your protection, grant it, that he may hear the Word of Allah" (9:6) — is known from revelation, held as creed, and articulated by this school in the distinctions this paper has tried to keep exact. (Closing; school-internal.)